

World in Brief: America due to unveil sanctions on Iran's trade partners; Mark Carney vows retaliation



Photograph: POOL/AFP via Getty Images

Pakistan's army chief, Asim Munir, will visit Tehran on Monday as his country continues to try to mediate an end to the war in **Iran**. Meanwhile **China** said it is “closely monitoring the situation in the Middle East and is actively committed to promoting peace talks”. On Monday America is expected to unveil new sanctions on **Iran's** trading partners. Iran said that would violate other countries' sovereignty.

Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, said his country would retaliate “dollar for dollar” against **America's new 50% tariffs**, with its own levies taking effect on September 8th. Donald Trump's tariffs, announced on Friday after trade talks collapsed, affect about \$20bn-worth of Canadian goods. Mr Trump had delayed the measures for three days to allow negotiations to continue.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine's** president, said that **holding wartime elections** would “destroy” his country by sowing division. Last week Mykhailo Fedorov, a former defence minister whose dismissal last month sparked widespread protests, called for elections. On Saturday Vladimir Putin, Russia's president, Putin

accused Ukraine of opening “Pandora’s box” by escalating attacks on Russian economic infrastructure.

Alibaba, a Chinese tech giant, said that it would sell shares worth HK\$80bn (\$10bn) to fund [its AI ambitions](#). On Thursday Alibaba announced that its quarterly revenues rose by 9% year on year, but profits fell by 75% as AI-related spending added up. Capital expenditure increased by 75%. Alibaba’s share price fell.

Britain’s government confirmed that energy companies had been placed on high alert after a **cyber attack** on a small gas-fired plant last month. *The Telegraph* reported that the site was taken offline for four days following the attack and that Iranian hackers were thought to be responsible. The shutdown had no effect on the country’s broader power supply.

Australia confirmed its first case of **avian influenza** (H5N1) in a mammal, having detected [the virus](#) in a long-nosed fur seal. The virus, which is deadly to birds, has devastated flocks since it emerged in the country in June. Seals are particularly vulnerable to transmission from seabirds.

The **Sydney Marathon’s** organisers revealed a participation medal depicting the Sydney Opera House, Sydney Harbour Bridge and, finally, the Allianz Arena—which is in Munich. Presumably the designers were trying to include the Allianz Stadium, which is in the Australian city. The marathon’s organisers are “not going to run from” the error—they will hand out the prize to the 40,000 people expected to take part on August 30th.

Word of the week: *Ongaku kissa*, a Japanese music café. Read how these venues, commonly known as listening or hi-fi bars, [are striking a chord abroad](#).

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

Rethinking Singapore's baby drought



Photograph: Shutterstock

Lawrence Wong, Singapore's prime minister, will deliver an address to a National Day rally on Sunday. Babies will be a central theme. Last year Singapore's total fertility rate hit a new low, falling to 0.87 births expected over a woman's lifetime, down from 0.97 in 2024. That is far below the 2.1 needed [to keep a population stable](#) without immigration. Mr Wong is expected to announce measures to make parenthood less onerous.

His new strategy will probably emphasise long-term financial support for families, rather than incentives to encourage more babies. Proposals include subsidised child care and flexible-work arrangements for parents of young children. He has reason to hope for some progress. Fertility rates in South Korea, among the lowest in the world, have crept up from 0.72 to 0.8 over the past two years, in part thanks to similar initiatives. Even if his plan fails, Mr Wong believes it should improve life for families in Singapore. "I may not get more babies," he said in June. "But it's still worth doing."

Reset or rebrand in Kazakhstan?



Photograph: Reuters

On Sunday Kazakhstan holds a parliamentary election. Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, its strongman president, is presenting it as a milestone in his project to build “a new Kazakhstan”, a government drive that began after a crackdown on protests in 2022 left more than 200 people dead. Recent constitutional changes have renamed the parliament and given it a new structure; it is certain to be dominated by a newly formed pro-presidential party.

Underneath the gloss of novelty, much about this election **is wearily familiar**. Critics have been arrested, and no genuine opposition party is on the ballot. Parliament is sure to remain a rubber-stamp affair. The changes to the constitution mean Mr Tokayev can run again for another “first” term as president in 2029, despite promising to abide by a one-term limit—a tactic autocrats in the region have used to cling to power. Expect the new Kazakhstan to bear a striking resemblance to the old one.

Rebuilding Colombia after a massive earthquake



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Colombia's musicians are rallying to help rebuild their country after [a devastating earthquake](#) on August 10th. More than 30 artists—including Karol G, reggaeton royalty—perform at a benefit concert in Bogotá on Sunday. Shakira, another star, has pledged to build ten schools in quake-struck Chocó. That could do more than most politicians have achieved in years.

Meanwhile the debt-burdened government is scrambling to pay for reconstruction. The damage is estimated at more than 30 trillion pesos (\$9.5bn). Abelardo de la Espriella, Colombia's right-wing president, has declared an economic emergency, which grants powers including the ability to redirect more corporate taxes towards reconstruction.

Yet political rows are undermining solidarity. The opposition accuses Mr de la Espriella of politicising the initial response by accepting foreign rescue personnel only from countries aligned with him ideologically, including America, Israel and El Salvador. Claudia Sheinbaum, Mexico's progressive president, accused Colombia of preventing the military's rescue workers from entering the country.

Shaking intensity

Weak     Strong



Weekend profile: Mike Ashley, the blokeish billionaire buying into luxury



Photograph: Alamy

Mike Ashley's name is not synonymous with refinement. The 61-year-old British billionaire built a fortune from Sports Direct, a bargain sportswear chain. He holds business meetings in pubs and challenges subordinates to drinking contests, once allegedly vomiting into a fireplace having sunk 12 pints. After purchasing Newcastle United football club, he made a point of watching from the stands, rather than the director's box. A video online shows him downing a pint of beer impressively quickly during a match.

Now Mr Ashley is bingeing on luxury firms. This week his conglomerate, Frasers Group, revealed it had built a 48% stake in [Hugo Boss](#), Germany's biggest upmarket fashion firm, falling just short of overall control. The board had recommended shareholders reject his offer. Last week Frasers bought Harvey Nichols, a posh but struggling chain of British department stores. In July it disclosed a 4% stake in Burberry, a luxury label.

The world of high fashion is a long way from Mr Ashley's first forays in business. After leaving school at 16 with just one qualification (a C grade in economics), he had dreams of becoming a squash player. Injuries put paid to that. His parents then remortgaged the family bungalow to lend him £10,000 (\$17,500 at the time), with which he set up a sports shop. By 2006 his chain

had become Britain's biggest sportswear retailer, in part by buying the merchandise of well-known brands that distressed sellers were offloading cheaply.

Some of Mr Ashley's business tactics fit his bruiser image. In 2007 he sold a 43% stake in Sports Direct, raising £929m. A few months later the shares had lost half their value; he called unhappy investors "cry babies". In 2016, following investigations into Sports Direct's working conditions, he admitted some warehouse workers had been paid below minimum wage. A year later an investment banker took him to court alleging that, during a "night of heavy drinking", Mr Ashley promised but subsequently failed to pay him £15m if he could help Sports Direct's share price to hit £8. Mr Ashley won on the grounds that the offer was not serious. "I like to get drunk. I'm a power drinker," he explained during the trial.

In 2022 Mr Ashley handed over day-to-day running of Frasers to his soon-to-be son-in-law, Michael Murray. It is he who is reportedly behind the shift away from budget offerings. But Mr Ashley still relishes a corporate scrap. This month, when asked by the *Financial Times* about his battle to take over Hugo Boss, he promised them "a bit of Dunkirk spirit".

Mini crossword

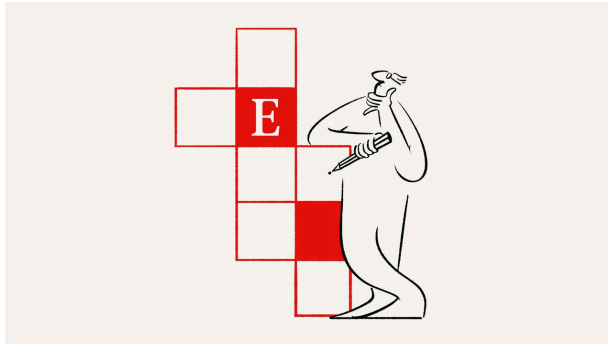


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - One deed consumes politician. It's a shock (6)

2 across - Let go of old drug boat (5)

3 across - New molar is crooked - typical! (6)

1 down - Trendy group swaps American for English disease (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Effect, influence (6)

2 across - Light boat (5)

3 across - Typical (6)

1 down - Contamination (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Julian Cooper, Aylesbury, Britain

Ezra Miller, Ottawa, Canada

José Miguel Ried, Santiago, Chile

They all gave the correct answers of: “Walk the Line”, corner a market, The Caucasian Chalk Circle, Area 51 and “Out, damned spot”. The theme is parts of a football pitch: goal (or half-way) line, corner arc, centre circle and penalty area and spot.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Johnny Cash song was adapted as the title of the 2005 biopic of the country singer?

Tuesday: What term, familiar from geometry, is used to describe the act of acquiring the bulk of a commodity's supply so as to drive up the price?

Wednesday: Which play by Bertolt Brecht is about a peasant girl who rescues a baby?

Thursday: Which American air-force base in Nevada is the subject of many conspiracy theories about alien visitors?

Friday: Which phrase does Lady Macbeth utter in Shakespeare's play as she tries to rub imaginary blood off her hands?

*The first thing I do in the morning
is brush my teeth and sharpen my
tongue.*

Dorothy Parker